

DANIEL'S DIARIES · HOME RESOURCE

Behaviour & Choices

Where your child meets the Traffic Director — and learns that feelings, thoughts and actions travel together, and every action has a junction where the traffic can turn.

SUPER SKILL · TRAFFIC DIRECTOR

BUILDS ON BRAIN TOWN

AGES 5–11

A guided introduction for grown ups to do at home.

Foundational Minds · Daniel's Diaries™



BEFORE YOU BEGIN

Read this part on your own first.

This resource introduces the Traffic Director — the Super Skill where all the others meet. It builds straight onto the town your child already knows, and is worth ten quiet minutes before you sit down together.

When a child believes their behaviour means they are naughty, or that actions simply happen to them, there is nothing to learn — only something to be ashamed of. The director idea changes that. Feelings, thoughts and actions become **traffic travelling through the town in a line** — and just before every action there is a junction, where the traffic can turn. Behaviour stops being a verdict. It becomes a turn, and turns can be learned.

What is actually happening in the brain

Feelings, thoughts and actions genuinely travel as a convoy: a feeling primes a thought, the thought primes an action, and on a well travelled road the whole line moves in under a second. The pause and choose ability lives in the town's planning centre — the last part of the brain to finish building, and offline whenever the alarm is ringing. Two practical truths follow: choosing is only possible in a calm enough body, and the gap between impulse and action genuinely widens with practice.

Directing, in plain terms

The traffic is the feeling, thought, action convoy. The junction is the small gap before an action where a turn is possible. A wrong turn is a behaviour that caused a problem — re-routable, never a verdict. And the director is the child's growing ability to pause at the junction and pick the turn. In the research this is **inhibitory control**, the working end of self regulation — and it strengthens exactly like a road: trip by trip.

Why a director, and why not "make good choices"

"Make good choices" asks for the outcome without teaching the mechanism, and quietly turns behaviour into a goodness test. The director frame separates the child from the turn: a wrong turn is traffic on a fast road, not a bad driver. And it honours the truth underneath everything in Daniel's Diaries — behaviour is communication. Traffic always starts somewhere, and directing improves fastest when adults read the whole journey, not just the turn.

THE PART THAT MATTERS MOST

No child can direct traffic in a storm. When the alarm is ringing, the planning centre is empty and the junction is invisible — calm comes first, choices come second, and the learning comes later still. **And the fastest way to grow a young director is to shrink the junction: offer two safe turns, not an open road. "Cuddle or space?" is directing practice.**

A note on timing: this conversation belongs to a calm, ordinary day — never the hour after a wrong turn.

THE WHOLE IDEA ON ONE PAGE

Traffic travels together. The junction is yours.

Here is the picture your child is about to meet. You do not need to deliver it perfectly. You only need to believe it, because it is true.

THE FEELING

arrives first, uninvited

A messenger rolls into town: big, real, and always allowed.

THE THOUGHT

jumps on a road

It picks a thought road: "that's not fair!", "I'll never win."

THE ACTION

takes the turn

At the junction the traffic turns: a shout, a walk away, a try again.

The feeling and the thought are never in trouble. The junction is where the director works. →



Choices live at the junction

Nobody chooses the feeling that arrives, and nobody chooses the thought that jumps on — both come fast and free. The turn is the choosable bit. Even a two second pause at the junction changes where the traffic goes, and every noticed junction widens the gap at the next one.



Wrong turns can be re-routed

A wrong turn is traffic on a fast road, not a bad driver. It is also a signal about the journey behind it — what the feeling and the thought were carrying. The re-route is simple and shame free: turn around, fix what you can, and take the other road. Taken often, the better turn becomes the easy one.



DANIEL SAYS

"Traffic can't turn while it's zooming. Slow the truck down first, then pick the turn. Works every time at my junction."

THE CONVERSATION

How to introduce it, in your own voice.

This is an offer, not a lesson. Sit beside your child, not across from them. Keep it light, leave room for them to wonder, and stop while they are still interested. Five minutes is plenty.

1 Open a door, gently

Start from the town they already know. Try: *"Remember your brain town? I found out how the traffic works. Want to hear?"* If they say not now, that is fine. The door stays open.

2 Plant the traffic

"Feelings, thoughts and actions travel together, like trucks in a line. A feeling rolls in first, a thought jumps on a road, and an action follows. On the big fast roads, the whole line moves in a blink."

3 Hand over the job

"And here is the best bit. Just before the action, there is a junction — a spot where the traffic can turn. Every junction needs a director, and in your town, that is you. You do not choose the feeling. You do not choose the thought that jumps on. You choose the turn."

4 Let them find a junction

"Can you remember a time you nearly did one thing, and did something else instead?" Nearly grabbed the toy but asked, nearly gave up but had one more go. Any answer is the right answer — they have already directed traffic without knowing it.

✓ LANGUAGE THAT OPENS IT UP

"Big feeling, hey. Let's slow the truck before the turn."

"Wrong turn, not a bad driver. What is the re-route?"

"You found the junction. Great directing."

✗ LANGUAGE THAT CLOSES IT DOWN

"You're being naughty."

"Why did you do that?"

"How many times do I have to tell you?"

The difference is what the behaviour means. The left column treats a turn as traffic that can be re-routed, and reads the journey behind it. The right column makes the turn a verdict on the driver — and a child who is the wrong turn has nothing left to direct. We are building a director who owns the junction, not a child who hides the traffic.

DO THIS TOGETHER

Map your junction.

This is the Traffic Director's first build, and your child keeps it. One page showing the convoy from a real moment, the junction, and two turns drawn side by side. Grab some paper and whatever they like to draw with.

10–15 minutes

Use a small, easy moment

No shame at the junction

- **Draw the convoy.** Pick one small, easy moment — funny is even better, and never their worst one. Draw its three trucks in a line: the feeling truck, the thought truck, and the action truck, labelled in their words.
- **Find the junction.** Draw the junction just before the action truck, with a little director's box beside it. *"This is where the traffic could turn. And this is where you stand."*
- **Draw two turns.** From the junction, draw the turn that happened and one other turn the traffic could have taken — side by side, both just roads. *"No trouble at this junction. We are only mapping."*
- **Be the director.** Have them sign the map as the town's traffic director. That signature is the whole point.

My junction map — directed by _____

If talking about behaviour feels risky

Some children's alarm rings the moment behaviour comes up, especially if talks have gone badly before. Map Daniel's traffic first and let your child direct, use a pretend moment, or map a proud turn instead of a tricky one. The mapping is identical — and a junction met safely is a junction they will come back to.



AFTER TODAY

Direct traffic out loud, together.

The Traffic Director grows through small, ordinary mentions — a home where naming a turn is as unremarkable as naming the weather.

Easy ways to keep it going

- Narrate your own junctions: *"Big frustrated truck rolling in. Slowing down... I am taking the walk away turn."* Children learn to direct by watching you do it.
- Praise turns, not goodness: *"You took the asking turn instead of the grabbing turn. Nice directing."*
- Re-route wrong turns without the courtroom — later, not in the heat: *"That turn caused a problem. The driver is fine. What is the repair?"*
- Shrink the junction when the traffic is fast: two safe turns, never an open road. *"Cuddle or space?" "Inside or outside?"*

HOLD THIS LIGHTLY

Wrong turns will keep happening — that is childhood, not failure. One calm re-route teaches more than a hundred lectures, because it is the re-route the brain records. **If today plants nothing more than "my feelings and thoughts are not in trouble, and my actions have a junction," you have done the whole job.**

What comes next

Once the junction feels familiar, your child is ready to work it.

Next • The Choice Point

Noticing the small gap between a feeling and what we do next, and learning to widen it.

Then • The Re-Route

A simple, shame free family script for after a wrong turn: turn around, fix what you can, take the other road.



DANIEL SAYS

"You found the junction today. That is a big one. A director who knows the traffic can turn is never stuck on one road. See you on the next road."